



January is still winter, but it's the month where beekeepers start looking ahead to spring.

JANUARY – PATIENCE, PREPARATION AND LOOKING AHEAD

January is often considered one of the quietest months in beekeeping.

The colonies are still deep in winter mode.

The weather remains cold.

Forage remains scarce.

The bees are focused entirely on survival.

Yet despite the lack of visible activity, January is an important month.

The actions taken now can have a significant impact on how colonies emerge into spring.

Good January beekeeping is not about opening hives or carrying out inspections.

It is about observation, preparation and patience.

WINTER IS FAR FROM OVER

Although the festive season has passed, winter is often at its harshest during January.

Cold temperatures, strong winds, prolonged rain and occasional snow continue to challenge colonies.

Food stores continue to decline.

Flying opportunities remain limited.

Many colonies spend days or even weeks without leaving the hive.

This is entirely normal.

The colony remains focused on conserving heat and energy until conditions improve.

WHAT THE BEES ARE DOING

Inside the hive, the winter cluster remains active.

The bees generate heat by vibrating their flight muscles.

Workers constantly rotate positions within the cluster.

Those on the outside move inward to warm up.

Those in the centre move outward in turn.



This allows the colony to maintain a stable temperature despite freezing conditions outside.

Many colonies remain broodless during January.

Others may begin raising small amounts of brood towards the end of the month.

This depends on local weather conditions, genetics and colony strength.

As brood rearing begins, food consumption increases significantly.

FOOD STORES ARE STILL THE PRIORITY

January is one of the most important months for monitoring stores.

Colonies that felt heavy in autumn can become surprisingly light by late winter.

This is particularly true if brood rearing has restarted.

Regular hefting remains one of the most valuable skills a beekeeper can develop.

By gently lifting the rear of the hive, you can estimate how much food remains without disturbing the colony.

Any colony that feels unusually light should be monitored carefully.

REALITY CHECK: Most winter colony losses are caused by starvation rather than cold weather.

USING FONDANT

Fondant remains the preferred emergency feed during January.

Unlike syrup, fondant requires minimal processing and can be consumed during cold weather.

Many experienced beekeepers place fondant above the cluster as a precaution.

The aim is not to encourage brood rearing.

The aim is simply to ensure the colony never runs out of food.

If fondant is required:

- Work quickly
- Avoid prolonged exposure of the cluster
- Minimise disturbance
- Position feed directly above the bees whenever possible

A few minutes of careful work can prevent a colony loss.



RESIST THE URGE TO INSPECT

One of the hardest lessons for new beekeepers is learning when not to intervene.

January is generally not a month for opening hives.

Every inspection:

- Breaks the cluster
- Causes heat loss
- Increases food consumption
- Places stress on the colony

Most information can be gathered externally.

You can assess:

- Hive weight
- Entrance activity
- Weather damage
- Signs of pests
- Security of roofs and straps

Without removing a single frame.

WATCHING FOR CLEANSING FLIGHTS

On mild winter days, you may notice increased activity at the hive entrance.

These flights are often referred to as cleansing flights.

The bees leave the hive briefly to defecate away from the colony.

Seeing bees flying on a bright winter day is usually a positive sign.

It demonstrates that the colony remains active and healthy.

However, the absence of flight activity during cold weather is also perfectly normal.

Weather conditions always influence what you see.

VARROA MANAGEMENT

January often follows the main winter varroa treatment period.



If oxalic acid treatments were applied in December, January provides an opportunity to review records and assess future management plans.

Good varroa control is a year-round process.

Winter treatments form only one part of a wider strategy.

Many beekeepers use January to review:

- Treatment records
- Monitoring results
- Mite levels from the previous season
- Future treatment plans

Strong spring colonies begin with good winter varroa control.

CHECKING FOR WINTER DAMAGE

Winter weather can be harsh on equipment.

January visits should include checks for:

- Loose roofs
- Fallen straps
- Water ingress
- Damaged stands
- Blocked entrances

Storm damage often becomes apparent during this period.

Small issues are easier to correct before they become major problems.

A quick walk around the apiary after severe weather is often worthwhile.

PESTS REMAIN A THREAT

Mice remain active throughout winter.

A warm hive filled with bees provides an attractive shelter.

Mouse guards should remain fitted and checked regularly.

In some locations, woodpeckers can also become problematic.

Repeated pecking may disturb the winter cluster and damage hive components.

Monitoring for signs of pest activity remains important throughout January.



PREPARING FOR SPRING

January marks the point where many beekeepers begin looking ahead.

Spring still feels distant.

Yet it often arrives sooner than expected.

This is an ideal time to:

- Build frames
- Repair equipment
- Assemble supers
- Organise spare boxes
- Order foundation
- Purchase replacement equipment

Waiting until spring often means competing with other beekeepers for supplies.

Preparation now reduces stress later.

REVIEWING THE PREVIOUS SEASON

Winter offers something that is often lacking during the active beekeeping season.

Time to think.

January is an excellent opportunity to review records and identify lessons from the previous year.

Ask yourself:

- Which colonies performed best?
- Which queens would you like to breed from?
- Which colonies struggled?
- Did swarm control work effectively?
- Were honey yields as expected?
- What would you change next season?

These reflections often improve beekeeping more than any piece of equipment ever will.

EDUCATION AND LEARNING

January is one of the best months for improving knowledge.



Many associations host winter lectures, training events and educational meetings during this period.

Topics commonly include:

- Swarm management
- Queen rearing
- Bee diseases
- Honey production
- Varroa control
- Advanced colony management

Investing time in learning now often pays dividends throughout the year.

PLANNING YOUR APIARY

January is also an excellent month for strategic planning.

Consider:

- Increasing colony numbers
- Producing nucs
- Requeening plans
- Expanding apiary locations
- Improving record keeping
- Upgrading equipment

A clear plan makes spring decision-making far easier.

THE IMPORTANCE OF PATIENCE

January rewards patience more than action.

Many beekeepers worry because very little appears to be happening.

The reality is that plenty is happening inside the hive.

The colony knows exactly what it needs to do.

Your role is simply to support it.

Provide:

- Adequate stores



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- A dry hive
- Protection from pests
- Minimal disturbance

Then allow the bees to do the rest.

LOOKING TOWARDS FEBRUARY

As January comes to an end, subtle changes begin.

Daylight hours slowly increase.

Some colonies start expanding brood nests.

Food consumption rises.

The first signs of spring preparation appear inside the hive.

February continues the winter story but introduces the first genuine signs of the season ahead.

Monitoring food stores becomes even more important.

Colony development slowly begins to accelerate.

For now, January remains a month of observation, preparation and restraint.

JANUARY TAKEAWAY

January is not about managing bees.

It is about supporting them.

Monitor stores.

Protect colonies from weather and pests.

Prepare equipment for the season ahead.

Most importantly, remain patient.

The bees are already preparing for spring, even if you cannot yet see it.

REALITY CHECK: The best January beekeepers spend more time preparing for spring than opening hives.